Revision Date:
11/01/2020

Background
Identity and residency must be verified as part of the application process for CalFresh.

Purpose:
This section describes the policies for identity and residency verification. There are no changes due to State legislation, this section is being updated after sunset review.

Policy:
The identity and residency of the person applying for CalFresh must be verified. When an Authorized Representative (A/R) applies on behalf of a household, the identity of both the A/R and head of household must be verified. Customers who do not have any form of identification (ID) may verify their identity through a collateral contact. A collateral contact is a verbal confirmation of a customer's identity by a person outside of the household.

To meet residency requirements, customers must live in the county in which they are applying for benefits. Customers may not receive benefits in more than one county or state, in the same month. The exception to this is victims of domestic violence residing in shelters for battered persons who's current CalFresh household includes the abuser. Refer to CFPG 63-124 for information on individuals living in battered persons shelters. Residency requirements do not require customers to live in a permanent dwelling, have a fixed mailing address or "intent to reside permanently" in the county. Persons on vacation in the county are not considered residents.

1. Verification Requirements:
Any documents which reasonably establish the applicant's identity or residency must be accepted, and no requirement for a specific type of document may be imposed. Identity verification needs to be provided only once by the customer, not for each application. Refer to Eligibility Policy and Procedure Guide (EPPG) "Reduced and No Fee DMV ID Cards" for information on how customers can get a Department of Motor Vehicle (DMV) ID for a reduced rate. Refer to "Desk Aid Verification Requirement Chart" in Eligibility Essentials for a detailed listing of acceptable forms of identity verifications.

2. Out of County / State Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT) Usage:
Customers may use their EBT benefits in other states or counties, so long as they remain residents of the county in which they applied for benefits or county benefits are being received in. Out of county or state EBT usage is not a reason to discontinue benefits for loss of residency. Refer to Processing Guide # 152-01 for guidance on determining residency when customers are using EBT benefits in another county or state.

3. Homeless Households:
Homeless households meet residency requirements by stating that they live in the county in which they are applying for benefits. Households may be considered homeless when they experience any of the following:

- Have no fixed, regular place to sleep at night
- Live somewhere that people do not normally live
- Live in a shelter designed to provide temporary accommodations

- Live for less than 90 days in another person's home. The 90-day period starts when the applicant or recipient moves into a temporary residence, and a new 90-day period will start if the customer moves into a different temporary residence

4. Whereabouts Unknown:
When mail is returned as "undeliverable" or "address unknown" it is necessary to determine if the customer is still a resident of the county in which they applied and are receiving benefits in. A discontinuance based on "whereabouts unknown" is not permitted for CalFresh cases. Refer to Processing Guide # 152-01 for guidance on determining residency for whereabouts unknown issues.

Other Program Impacts:
None

References:
ACL 15-94; ACL 15-94E; ACL 10-01
MPP 63-300.5; MPP 63-401
CalFresh Processing Guide # 152-01

Sunset Date:
This policy will be reviewed for continuance on or by 11/30/2023.

Approval for Release:

RW, 11-4-20

RICK WANNE, Director
Eligibility Operations